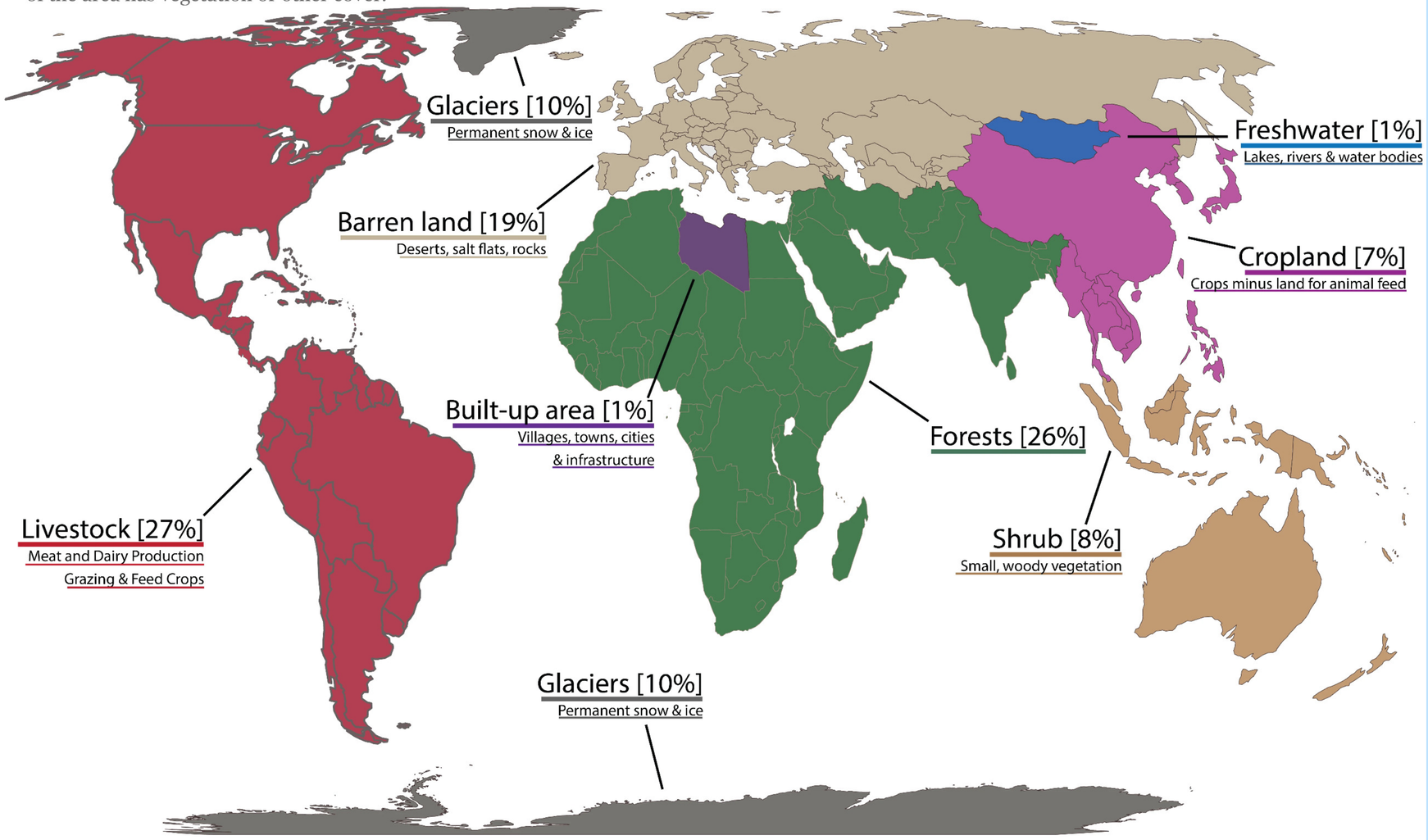
How the world's land is used: Total area sizes by type of use & land cover

Our World in Data

Global surface area if land was aggregated by usage or terrain cover. Land categories are not shown by their distribution around the world but are representative of the total area that they cover.
Land uses as a percentage of global land area area are shown in square brackets.

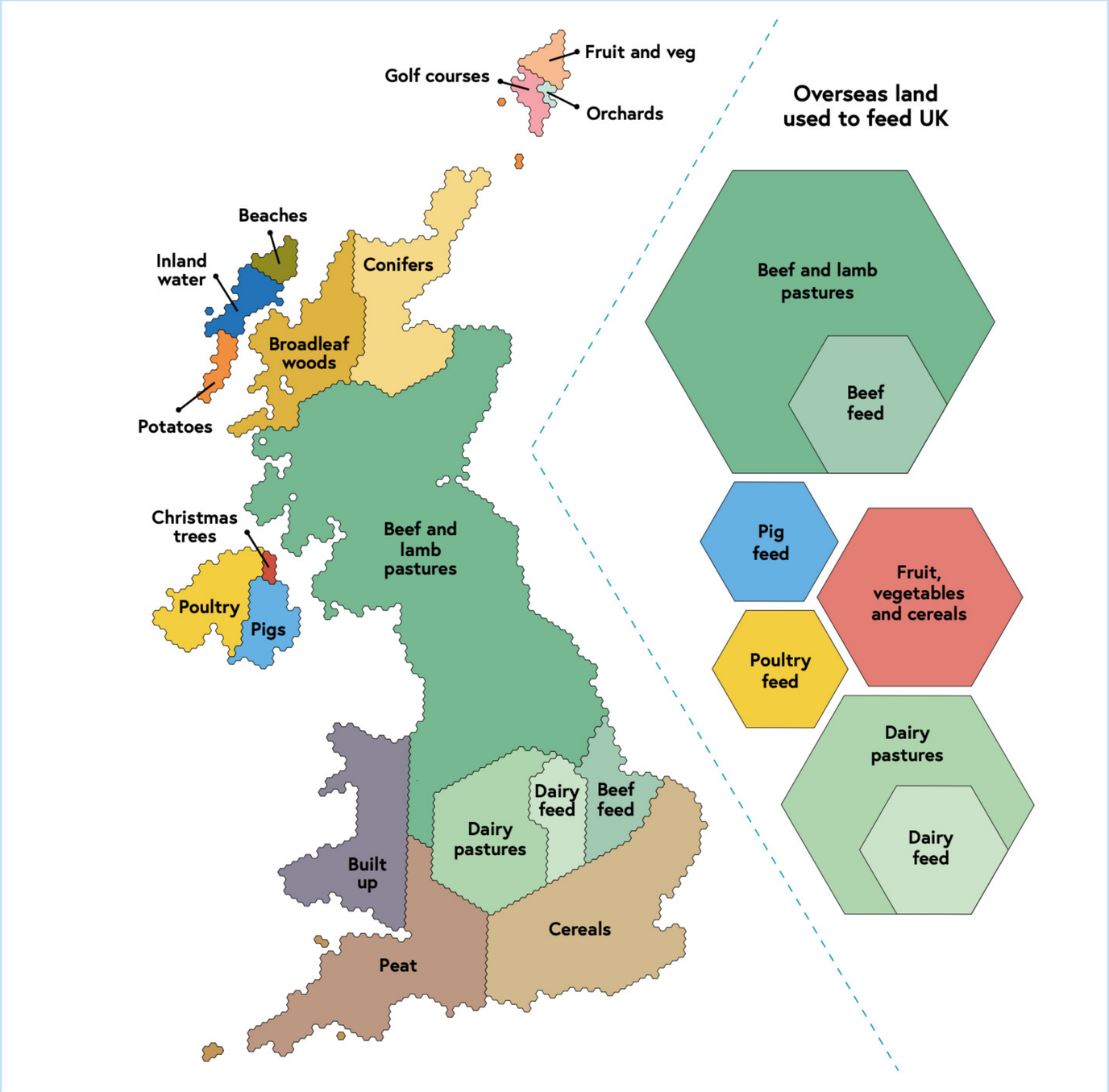
– Cropland is shown as land area used for crop production minus area used for production of animal feed.
– Livestock area is inclusive of both grazing land and cropland for animal feed. 'Barren land' refers to land cover in which less than one-third of the area has vegetation or other cover.



Based on data by the UN Food and Agricultural Organization (FAO) and World Bank Statistics. This map is based on the equal-area Eckert IV map projection.
The data visualization is available at OurWorldinData.org. There you find research and more visualizations on this topic.

Licensed under CC-BY-SA by the authors Hannah Ritchie and Max Roser.

Source: OWID, 2018



Source: National Food Strategy (2021) via Carbon Brief



Government of the United Kingdom

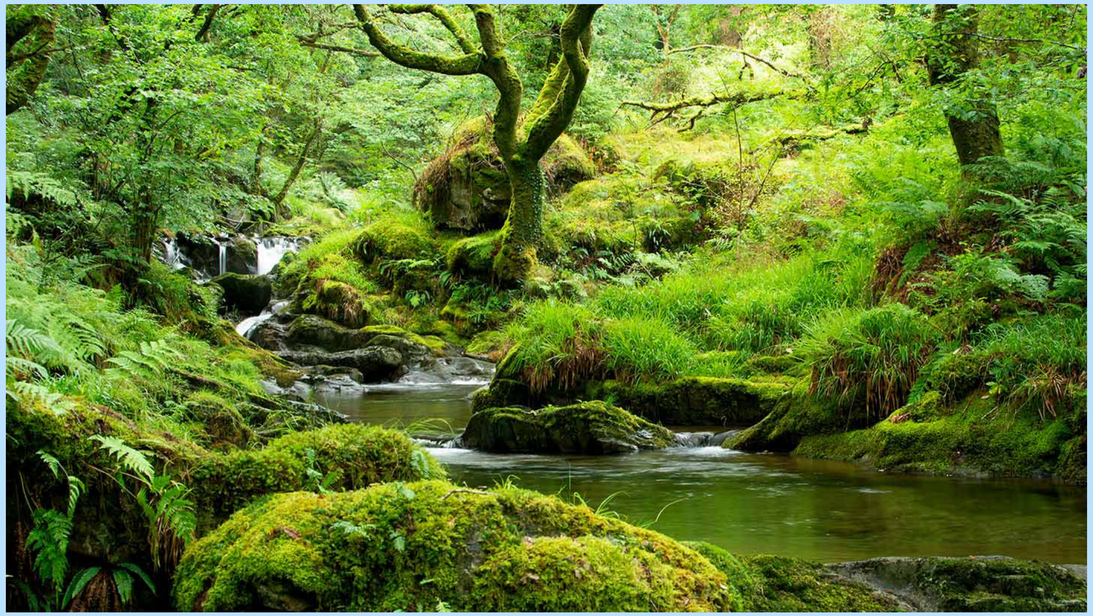
Department for Environment, Food & Rural Affairs

The Land Use Framework for England

Presented to Parliament
by the Secretary of State for Environment, Food & Rural Affairs
by Command of His Majesty

March 2026

So what are England’s goals?









“we have enough land”

Energy infrastructure: an extra 1% of England

Urban expansion: an extra 1% of England

Nature recovery: an extra 6% of England







Define framework…

“we want it [the LUF] to inform decisions, not impose them”

∴ no prescriptions, no commitments

Action points?

Defra Land Use Unit

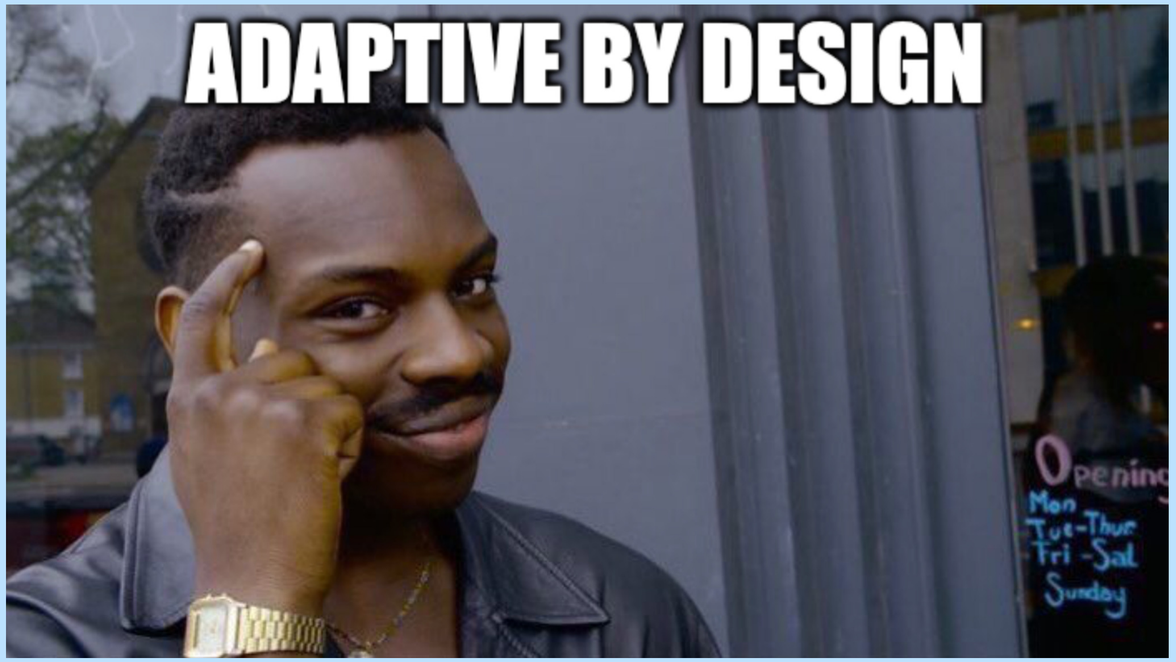
climate change land use modelling

spatially discriminatory “agricultural” subsidies

expanded public land purchases for nature recovery?

But how?


MuLtIfUnCtIoNaLiTy


ADAPTIVE BY DESIGN
Mon
Tue-Thur
Fri -Sat
Sunday

Passing the buck

Local Plans, i.e. local authorities

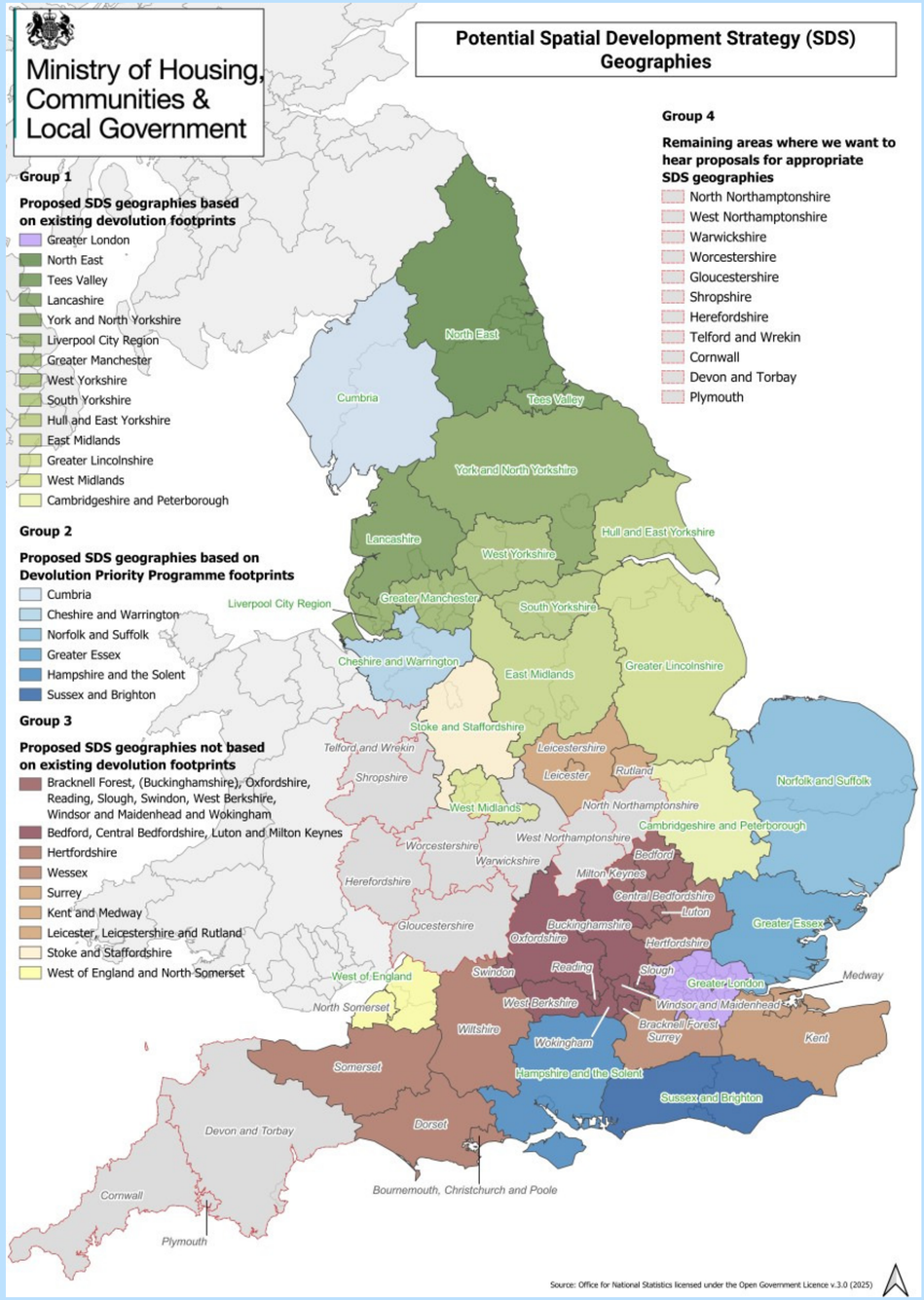
Strategic Spatial Energy Plan

Spatial Development Strategies

Environmental Delivery Plans

Spatial Development Strategies

Part 2 of Planning and Infrastructure Act



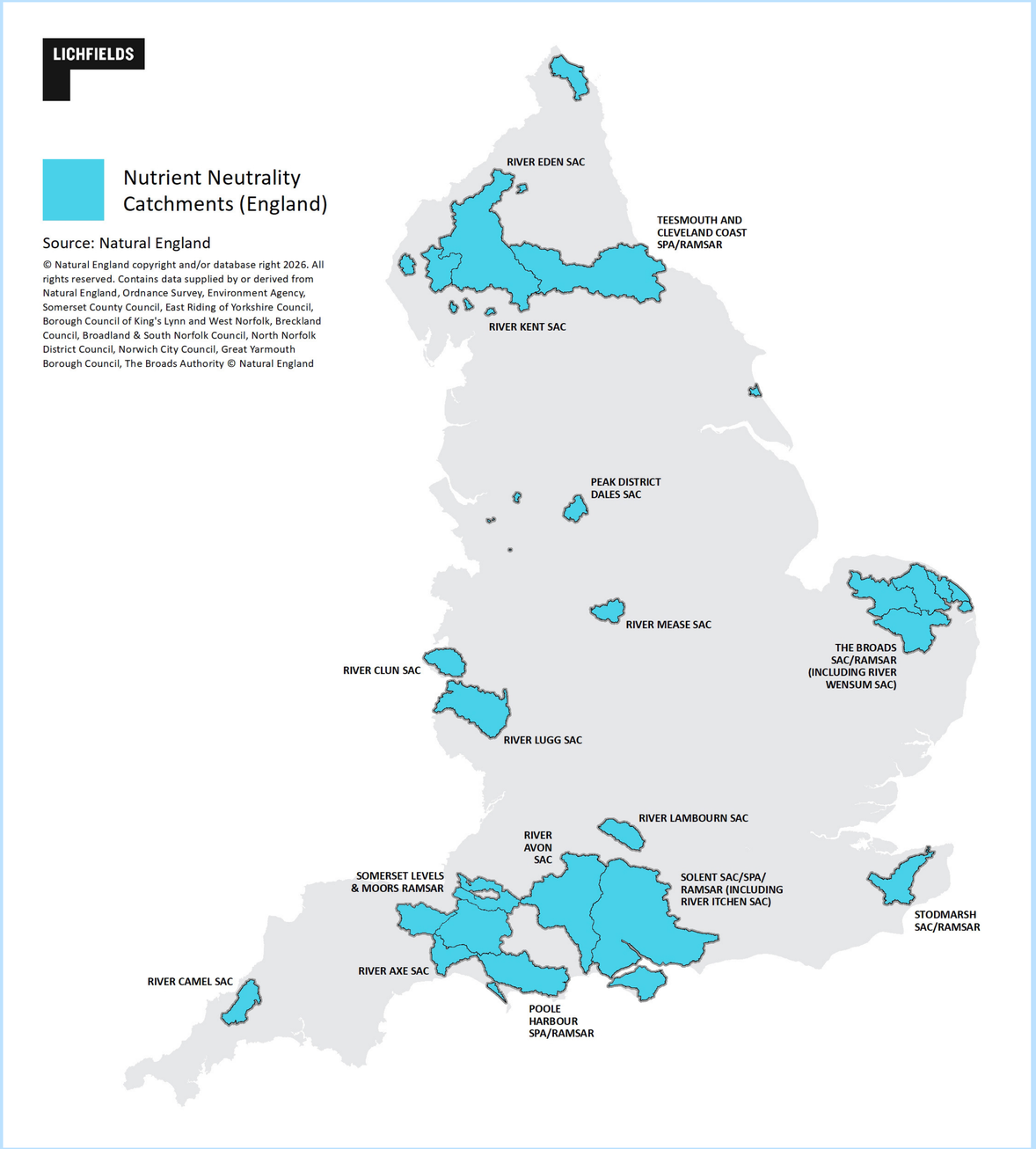
Source: MHCLG

but they cannot spatially specify!

12D(12): a spatial development strategy must not … specify particular sites where development should take place

so what can? **Environmental Delivery Plans?**

Part 3 of Planning and Infrastructure Act



Source: Lichfields

Other interventions?

Landscape Recovery Scheme

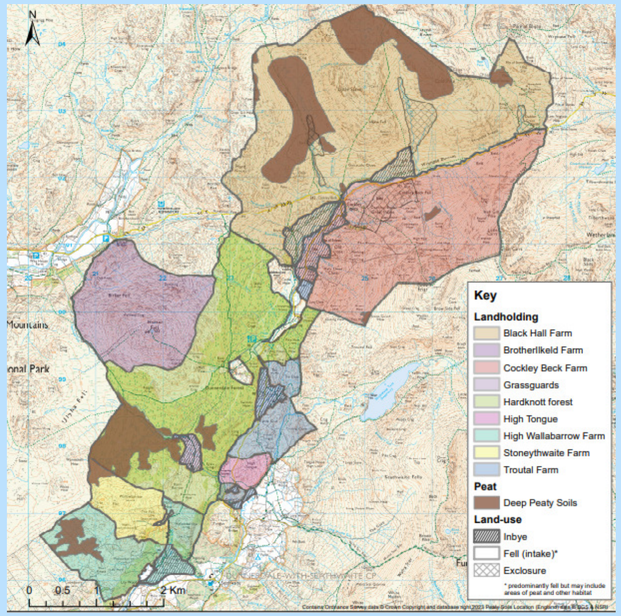
promised coverage: 1.8%

actual coverage: ~0.29%

promised funding: £800m/year

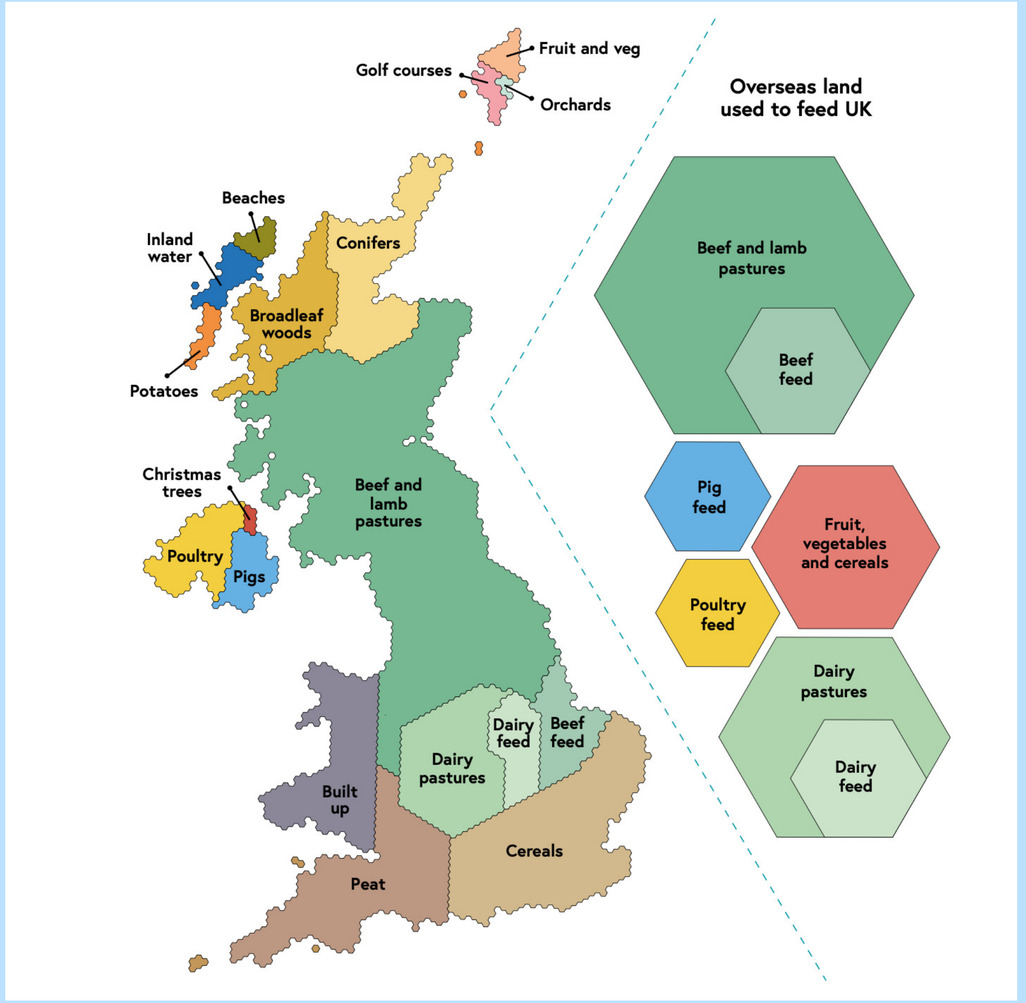
actual funding: £25m/year





So how to incentivise land use change envisioned in LUF?

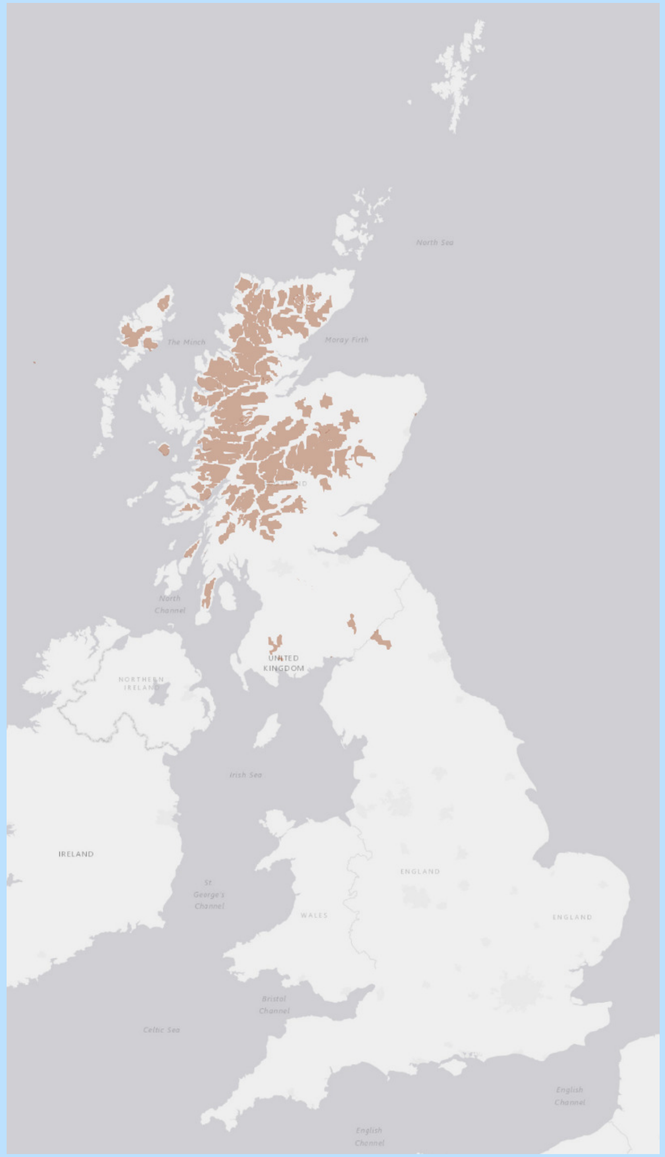




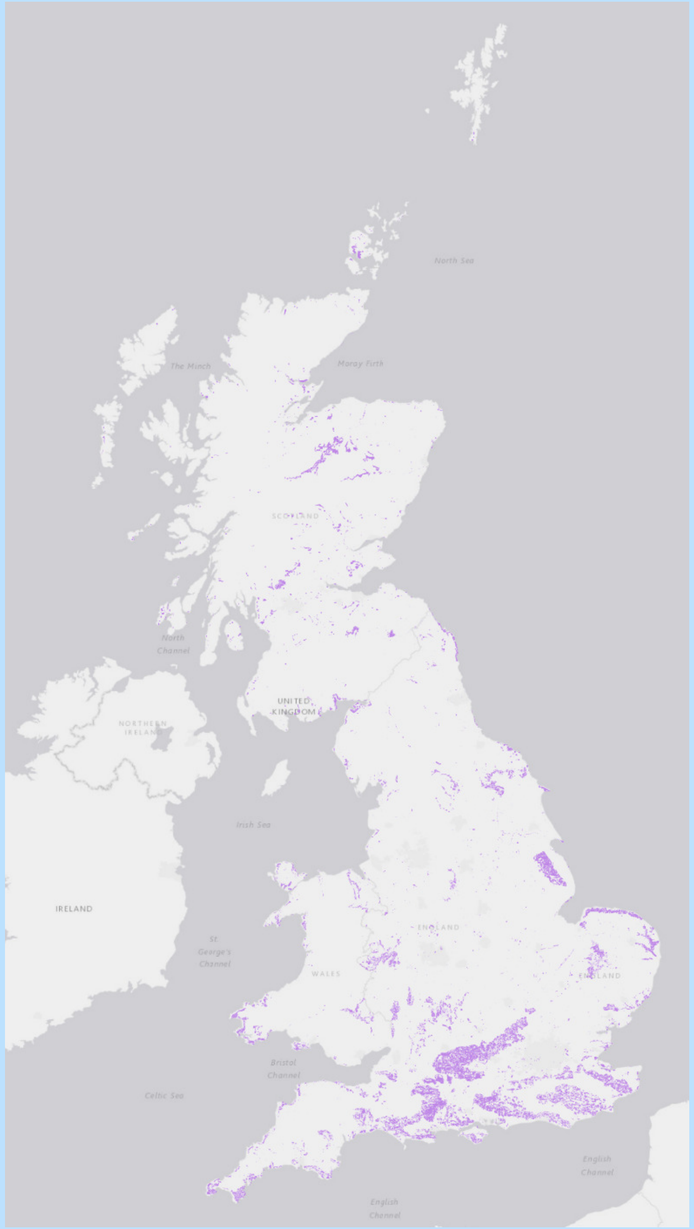
So what should be done?



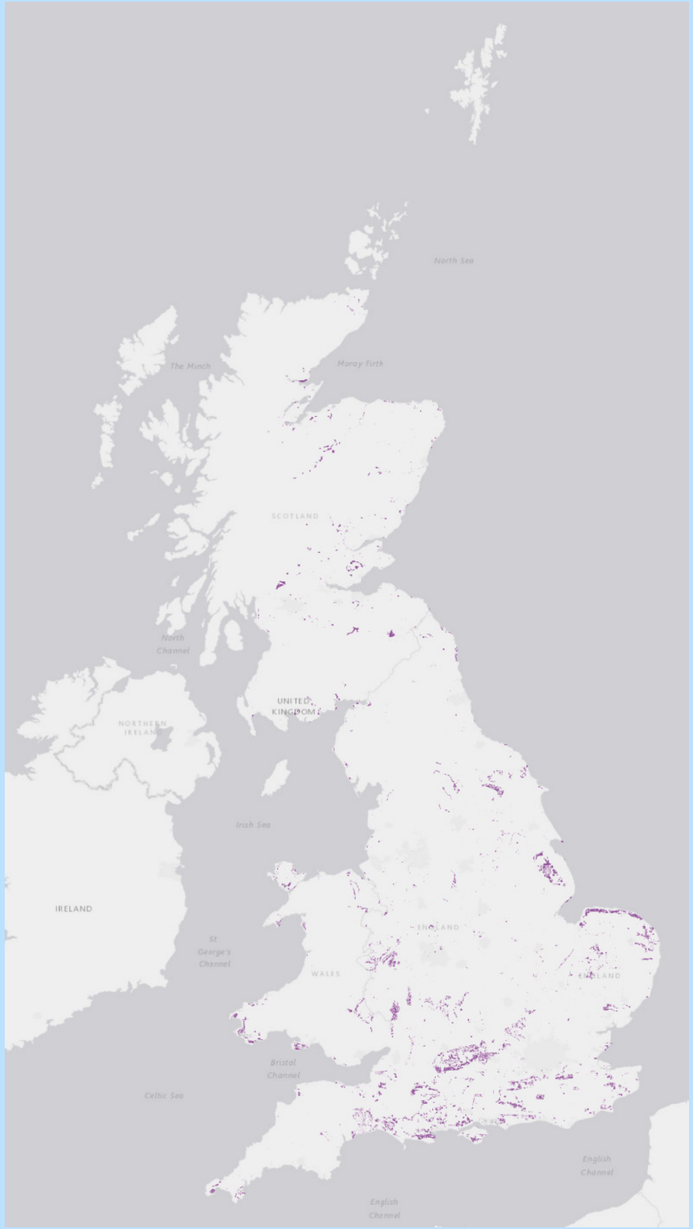
30% Protected Areas



10% Strictly Protected Areas



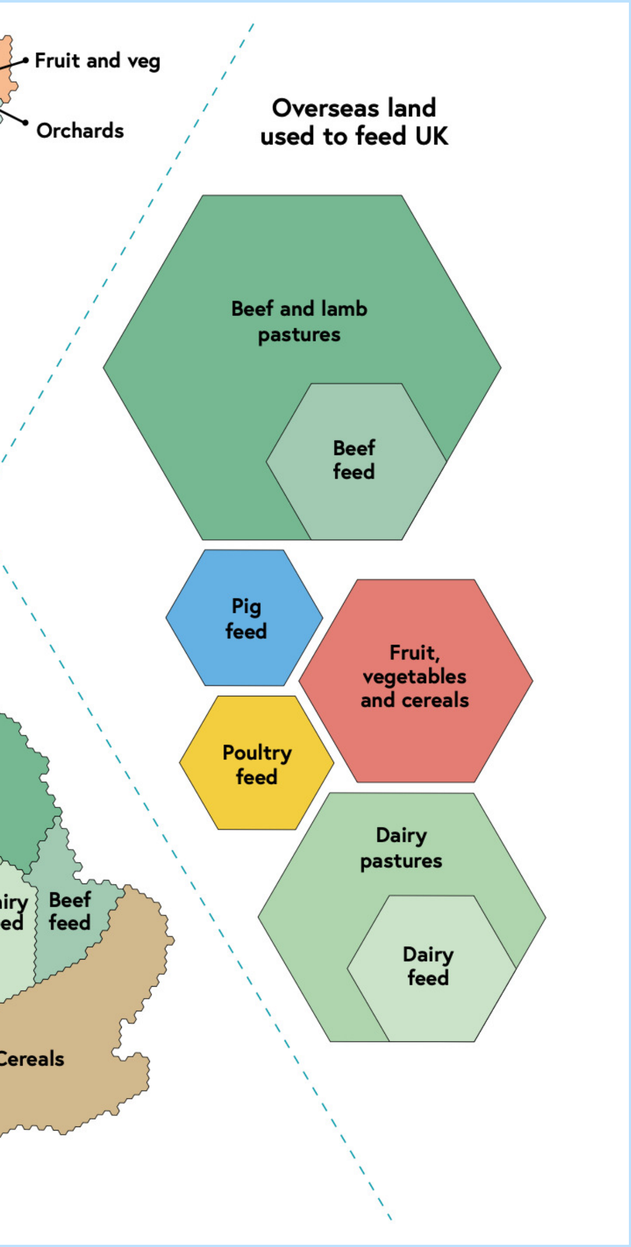
Productive Arable Land Overlap



Highly Productive Arable Land Overlap

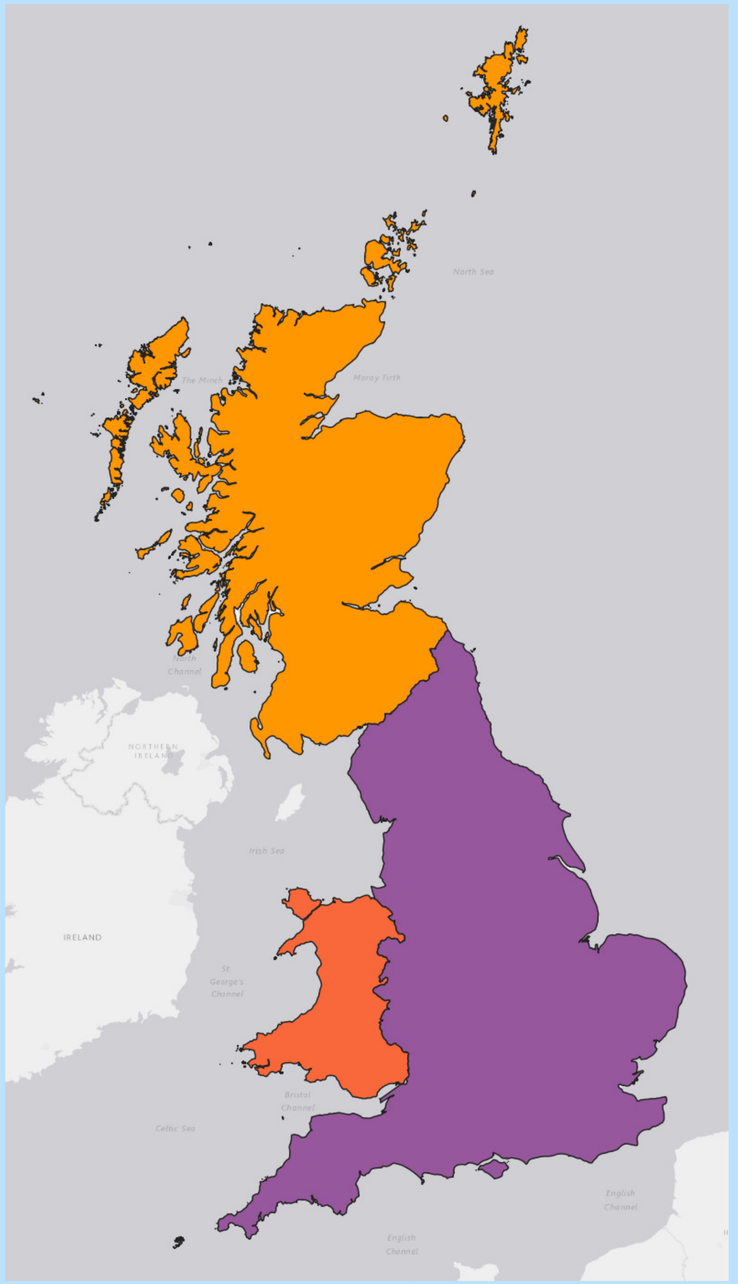

Ted
£ value of land use change incentives

Things to consider



leakage

and devolution



So what next?

large-scale land use change relates to agriculture

existing nature mitigation strategies relate to anything but agriculture

∴ we need alternative strategies for large-scale land use change!